Modes of Communication

Communication is the primary process of sharing messages and information between any set of individuals using certain defined rules, symbols, behaviours, and signs. There are three major modes for this process of exchanging messages and information, as briefed below.

1. Interpretive Communication
2. Interpersonal Communication
3. Presentational Communication

Interpretive Communication

This communication mode is also referred to as “one-way communication”. In interpretive communication mode, the details and information that the sender conveys are interpreted by the receiver in its original form without any alterations. The target’s role is to understand the message in both spoken and written forms while keeping various aspects in mind. For example, in any class, the learners might not completely understand every word that the teacher says but are always expected to understand the topics’ main coverage. Some major highlights of interpretative communication are:

1. Learners start with understanding, interpreting, and analyzing the details that they hear, read, or view on various topics.
2. This communication model involves interpreting the intents of the author or the producer.
3. There is currently no alternative available to active negotiations of the meanings with the speakers, writers, or the producers.

Interpersonal Communication

This communication mode is the process in which people exchange data and information via verbal and non-verbal messages. This is not a mediated communication mode, occurring when anyone interacts or attempts to influence one another mutually to manage the relationships. Even though the interpersonal communication mode can involve written, oral, and non-verbal communication forms, this term is applied only and mainly to the spoken communication taking place between two or more individuals on a personal or face to face level. Here is a list of examples that interpersonal communication involves:

1. Text messages
2. Emails
3. Debates
4. Interactive sessions
5. Telephonic conversations
6. Personal Interviews

Presentational Communication

This is the other one-way communication mode that facilitates the interpretation by members of any other group where there is no direct opportunity for active negotiations of the said and understood meanings between members of any two groups. With this communication mode, a

person speaks to the audience after being rehearsed, scripted, or pre-prepared. Some major highlights of presentational communication are given below:

1. For ensuring that the intended audience successfully interprets the presenters' needs and the presenter is well-versed with the language and culture of the audience.
2. There is no direct opportunity for engagement with a larger audience base in this communication mode.

Key Differences between Communication Modes

Based on Type

- **Interpersonal:** This is a two-way communication model.
- **Interpretive:** This is a one-way communication mode.
- **Presentational:** This is also a one-way communication mode

Based on Negotiation

- **Interpersonal:** There is a possibility of active negotiations of meanings between the individuals.
- **Interpretive:** There is no possibility of active negotiations with any producer, speaker, writer, or author.
- **Presentational:** There is no availability of any reasonable means for engaging the mass.

Based on Communication Mode

- **Interpersonal:** The main modes of messages' convey and interpretation are speaking, listening, reading, and writing.
- **Interpretive:** The main modes of messages' convey and interpretation are listening to texts, viewing, and reading.
- **Presentational:** The main modes of messages' convey and interpretation are speaking and writing.

Based on Examples

- Interpersonal: Text messages, social media, etc.
- Interpretive: radio news, literature, speeches, articles, etc.
- Presentational: Reports, flyers, short stories, etc.

Importance of Three Modes of Communication

Here are the importances of Interpretive, Interpersonal, and presentation communication modes:

1. Help in the maintenance of a smoother flow for conveying information.
2. Help in devising any plan or strategy for reaching a pre-defined goal.
3. Help in building soft skills and cordial relationships.
4. They help in making the entire decision-making process more effective and lesser time-consuming.
5. With the help of these, conflict management and problem-solving get easier.

What are interpersonal skills?

Interpersonal skills (also called employability skills, social skills, people skills, or soft skills) are what you use to understand, communicate, interact, and relate with other people.

Or

People's *interpersonal skills* are their abilities and strategies for interacting with others. They can help you build personal and professional relationships, as well as communicate and work with others effectively. Interpersonal skills combine personality traits and various social skills.

Many people refer to *interpersonal skills* as soft skills, people skills, emotional intelligence, or employability skills.

Why Are Interpersonal Skills Important in the Workplace?

Many jobs involve a degree of teamwork and collaboration. If employees can't communicate effectively, are unable to find common ground, or are unwilling to help each other, it can result in an increase in upsetting situations at work, decreased productivity, and an overall toxic atmosphere.

And it's more than that. According to the Future of Jobs report for 2020–2025, there's a growing demand for interpersonal skills, such as negotiation and emotional intelligence.

List of Key Interpersonal Skills

Here's a list of interpersonal skills that are most valued in the 21st century:

1. Communication
2. Leadership
3. Decision-making
4. Problem-solving
5. Organization
6. Social skills
7. Collaboration
8. Emotional intelligence
9. Adaptability
10. Stress management

1. Communication Skills

It's no accident that communication skills top the list. There's so much more to effective interpersonal communication than speaking coherently. It's also about listening, understanding what the other person is saying, and reading non-verbal cues.

Examples of interpersonal communication skills include:

- Verbal and nonverbal communication
- Body language

- Public speaking
- Presentation skills
- Negotiation
- Mediation
- Persuasion
- Active listening
- Conflict resolution
- Assertiveness
- Diplomacy
- Giving and receiving feedback

Improving communication skills can be difficult, especially for introverted and neurodivergent individuals. If you'd like to try it, you might want to enroll in online courses, such as Communication Skills Master Class from Udemy.

2. Leadership

Being a leader has nothing to do with corporate seniority levels. It's an interpersonal skill that helps inspire others to work on the things you're passionate about. Leadership skills can be learned, but they're highly correlated with your character traits. That's why certain people become natural leaders, even if they don't start meetings with an icebreaker. If you wish to improve your ability to lead others, you can try online courses such as Leading People and Teams from Coursera.

Samples of interpersonal skills in leadership include:

- Management skills
- Mentoring
- Motivation
- Inspiring others
- Reliability
- Dependability
- Responsibility

3. Decision-Making

Decision-making skills are essential for managers. Do you empathize with others enough to see the implications of your decisions? Can you communicate an unpopular decision in a way that will make people see your point? Or if a decision is to be made by a group, can you weigh all the pros and cons? And finally, are you mature enough to be held accountable for your decisions?

Decision-making requires interpersonal skills, such as:

- Problem analysis
- Making evidence-based decisions
- Executive decision-making
- Brainstorming
- Consensus-building

4. Problem-Solving

Employers don't want workers who give up when faced with an issue. They want people who exhibit problem-solving skills and fix an issue themselves or know when and how to find people who can do that at hand.

Some examples of interpersonal skills in problem-solving include:

- Drawing conclusions
- Insight
- Experimenting
- Creative thinking
- Persistence
- Questioning

5. Organization

Organizing your work is even more important in the era of remote jobs and flexible work arrangements. Employers look for particular traits and want reliable workers who can keep deadlines, prioritize tasks, and perform their jobs efficiently.

Among interpersonal abilities, organization skills could mean:

- Time management
- Administrative skills
- Planning
- Strategizing
- Goal-setting
- Working with deadlines

6. Social Skills

Humans are social creatures. Even if you enjoy solitude, you must have some basic social skills to be successful at work. Sitcom characters like Sheldon Cooper can be adorable, but in real life, saying improper things to others is not cute. It's worth learning how to start a conversation or how to introduce yourself casually—they're basic things that can make work life more manageable.

Interpersonal skills include social abilities, such as:

- Relationship building
- Developing rapport
- Networking skills
- Social awareness

7. Collaboration

Most 21st-century companies require their employees to collaborate effectively, form cross-functional teams, share knowledge, and help one another. It doesn't matter if you're a

software engineer or a cashier at McDonald's—your boss will expect you to work with others at some point.

Interpersonal skills in collaboration mean:

- Teamwork skills
- Team building
- Delegation of duties

8. Emotional Intelligence

You might be the smartest person in the room. Still, if you say hurtful remarks about your colleagues and dismiss other people's ideas without consideration, you won't take another step on your career ladder.

Interpersonal skills associated with emotional intelligence include:

- Self-awareness
- Empathy
- Cultural sensitivity
- Open-mindedness
- Tolerance
- Patience

9. Adaptability

Workplaces change. The COVID-19 pandemic has shown that businesses and employees must be able to adapt to various work conditions. Accepting changes and overcoming challenges can make you more resilient, successful at work, and more relaxed in the long run.

Aspects of adaptability related to interpersonal skills include:

- Flexibility
- Resilience
- Positive attitude
- Humor

10. Stress Management

Everyone feels tense sometimes. However, being unable to work because of stress is a serious issue, not only for the employer but also for you. Too much stress can lead to burnout and depression. Nowadays, it's very important to know how to handle stress productively.

Examples of stress management as an interpersonal skill include:

- Reacting to stress
- Staying calm under pressure
- Deescalation techniques
- Relaxation techniques

As you see, you can't underestimate the importance of interpersonal skills in the workplace. Communication and interpersonal skills are important for successful project management, building team dynamics, and effective and efficient cross-departmental collaboration.

Importance of Interpersonal skills

- **Effective Communication:** Enables clear and articulate expression of ideas, thoughts, feelings, and body language, facilitating understanding and avoiding misunderstandings
- **Active Listening:** Fosters attentive and empathetic listening, leading to better comprehension and building stronger connections with others
- **Empathy:** Allow individuals to understand and share the emotions and perspectives of others, promoting compassion and building deeper relationships
- **Conflict Resolution:** Provides the ability to resolve disagreements and conflicts constructive and mutually beneficial manner, fostering harmony and collaboration
- **Collaboration and Teamwork:** Facilitates effective cooperation, coordination, and synergy among team members, improving productivity and collective success
- **Leadership:** Interpersonal skills plays a crucial role in leadership. Leadership empowers individuals to inspire and motivate others, guide teams toward shared goals, and create a positive and inclusive work environment
- **Networking:** Helps individuals build and maintain a strong professional network, opening doors to opportunities, support, and growth

In fact, according to a recent study conducted by McKinsey on the future of remote work, there is a striking correlation. Specifically, the study found that employees who experience a greater sense of inclusion in workplace communication are nearly 5 times more likely to report a significant increase in productivity.

What are Intrapersonal Skills?

Intrapersonal skills refer to a person's ability to understand and manage their thoughts, emotions, and behaviors. These skills involve self-awareness, self-reflection, and personal growth. Intrapersonal skills encompass a range of competencies such as emotional intelligence, self-confidence, adaptability, decision-making, self-motivation, intrapersonal communication, and time management.

Developing intrapersonal skills allows individuals to gain insights into their strengths, weaknesses, and values, enabling them to make better choices, set and achieve goals, manage stress, and maintain a healthy work-life balance. Intrapersonal skills, including effective

intrapersonal communication, are vital in self-improvement, personal development, and overall well-being.

Importance of Intrapersonal skills

- **Self-Awareness:** Enables individuals to understand their strengths, weaknesses, values, and goals, leading to better self-management and decision-making
- **Emotional Intelligence:** Involves recognizing and managing one's own emotions and understanding the emotions of others, fostering better interpersonal relationships and communication
- **Self-Confidence:** Contributes to a positive self-perception and belief in one's abilities, leading to increased resilience, assertiveness, and the ability to take risks
- **Adaptability and Resilience:** Helps individuals navigate and cope with change, challenges, and setbacks, fostering flexibility and the ability to bounce back
- **Decision-making and Problem-solving:** Enhances critical thinking, analysis, and judgment skills, enabling effective decision-making and creative problem-solving.
- **Self-Motivation and Goal-Setting:** Empowers individuals to set and pursue meaningful goals, maintain focus, and stay motivated, leading to personal achievement and growth
- **Time Management:** Involves effective organization and prioritization of tasks and responsibilities, optimizing productivity and achieving a healthy work-life balance

Interpersonal vs. Intrapersonal Skills: The Differences

Context	Interpersonal Skills	Intrapersonal Skills
Focus of Skills	Interactions, and relationships with others	Self-awareness and self-management
Context of Application	Social and professional settings	Personal growth and self-improvement
Impact on External Relationships	Directly influences the ability to connect and build relationships	Indirectly impacts external relationships through personal growth

Nature of Development	Active engagement with others, practice, and feedback	Introspection, self-reflection, and personal development activities
External vs. Internal Focus	Limited scalability due to physical constraints	Highly scalable, can accommodate large numbers of learners
Impact on Success	Crucial for success in professional settings, effective communication, collaboration, and leadership	Important for personal and professional success, self-confidence, adaptability, emotional resilience

Similarities Between Interpersonal and Intrapersonal Skills

While interpersonal and intrapersonal skills have distinct focuses and applications, they also share similarities. Here are the top five points highlighting their similarities:

- **Self-awareness:** Both interpersonal and intrapersonal skills require a level of self-awareness. Understanding one's emotions, strengths, weaknesses, and values is essential for effective communication, self-management, and healthy relationships
- **Emotional Intelligence:** Both skill sets involve emotional intelligence. Emotional intelligence encompasses recognizing, understanding, and managing emotions in oneself and others. It is crucial in establishing meaningful connections, resolving conflicts, and fostering empathy
- **Effective Communication:** Both interpersonal and intrapersonal skills rely on effective communication. Whether expressing oneself to others or engaging in internal self-talk, clear and concise communication is essential for accurately conveying thoughts, emotions, and intentions
- **Self-reflection:** Both skill sets benefit from self-reflection. Reflecting on experiences, actions, and beliefs allows individuals to gain insights, learn from past situations, and adjust for personal growth and improvement
- **Personal Growth:** Both interpersonal and intrapersonal skills contribute to personal growth. Developing these skills leads to an enhanced understanding of oneself and others, improved relationships, increased emotional intelligence, and overall self-improvement

Conclusion

Developing interpersonal and intrapersonal skills is crucial for personal and professional growth. Interpersonal skills empower individuals in relationships, communication, collaboration, and empathy, while intrapersonal skills foster self-awareness, emotional intelligence, resilience, and self-management. Balancing these skills is essential for strong connections, achieving goals, and work-life balance.

What are the interpersonal barriers?

Barriers To Interpersonal Communication : Interpersonal communication is when two or more people communicate with each other. It consists of both verbal and nonverbal components. The actual words we say are referred to as verbal communication. Gestures, facial expressions, voice tones, and actions are examples of nonverbal communication that often convey more about our feelings than the words we say. Barriers to interpersonal communication are frequently the result of personal attitudes or behaviours that we can alter if we evaluate them carefully.

The following are the types of barriers to interpersonal communication that have been identified:

- Environmental Barrier
- Language/Semantic Barriers
- Psychological Barriers
- Socio-Cultural Barriers

Barriers To Interpersonal Communication: Physical/Environmental Barriers

There are many barriers to interpersonal communication that emerge in our surroundings or environment, causing communication challenges or confusion.

- **Noise In External Surroundings:** One of the interpersonal communication barriers is noise from the external environment. Noises such as those of traffic, any surrounding workplaces or construction sites, may become barriers to effective interpersonal communication.
- **Time and Distance:** Physical distance between people can become one of the barriers to effective interpersonal communication. The world's time zones are not all the same. Time and distance may thus become a barrier to interpersonal communication.

- **Communication System Defects:** Telephones, fax machines, and computers are all examples of communication instruments or machines that can create technical issues and communication barriers. The Internet network could go down, or the microphone of your laptop could be making a lot of noise.
- **Incorrect Medium Choice:** It's crucial to use the right medium for effective interpersonal communication, be it emails, mobile phones, or telephones. Incorrect choice of medium can become barriers to interpersonal communication.

Barriers To Interpersonal Communication: Language/Semantic Barriers

Language barriers like linguistic or semantic errors and mispronunciation of words could disrupt interpersonal communication. Some examples of language barriers to interpersonal communication are listed below:

- Communication might be hampered by the use of multiple languages or the lack of a common language between those communicating. There needs to be a common language in which two people can communicate. Otherwise, it can turn into barriers to effective interpersonal communication.
- Words with identical pronunciations but different meanings (homophones) may become barriers to interpersonal communication as well. For example, except-accept, fair-fare, council-counsel, and principle. Hence, for smooth communication, a person must have a sound understanding of language.

Barriers To Interpersonal Communication: Psychological Barriers

Psychological barriers are formed in our minds. These barriers to interpersonal communication are complicated. We are frequently confronted with psychological conflicts because of our personal life experiences and our surroundings. Such barriers may seem complicated, but they can be overcome if one has the zeal to work on them. Some of the examples of psychological barriers to interpersonal communication are listed could be being too overpowered by one’s emotions, daydreaming, a pessimistic worldview, a negative attitude, and so on.

Barriers To Interpersonal Communication: Socio-Cultural Barriers

Culture refers to a way of life, a set of values, what is right or wrong, or a set of principles a group of people follows. There are many different cultures and principles around the world. Many variations between cultures may create barriers to effective interpersonal communication. Some examples of socio-cultural barriers to interpersonal communication

could be differences in meanings of nonverbal signs, a different understanding of proximity, and so on.

Barriers to Interpersonal Communication: How To Overcome

Let us now see how the barriers to interpersonal communication can be overcome.

- **Use Simple Language:-** Use simplified language in order to have an efficient interpersonal communication process. Keep it simple and easy to comprehend when speaking.
- **Master The Skill Of Listening:-** Listen carefully and attentively to improve interpersonal communication.
- **Maintain Your Composure When Discussing:-** Maintaining your composure when speaking or negotiating with anyone will help you stay on course to achieve your goal.
- **Ask For Feedback:-** Asking for feedback after a meeting, discussion, or group project can help you understand where to improve. This will assist you in identifying the areas in which you should improve.

In conclusion, we can say that there are many barriers to interpersonal communication. These barriers include environmental barriers, language/semantic barriers, psychological barriers and socio-cultural barriers. These barriers to interpersonal communication can be overcome by using simple yet effective strategies that have been discussed in the article.

Negotiation Skills

Negotiations are formal discussions between people who have different aims or intentions, especially in business or politics, during which they try to reach an agreement. They try to reach a common ground eliminating their differences.

Negotiation in business has become one of the most important skills and abilities. While negotiation will happen between two parties for reaching an agreement, it is said that the most effective negotiator will be both competing as well as collaborating. An effective negotiator is one who creates value for the other while claiming value for the self. There must be meaningful give and take that should happen in negotiation.

Negotiation should always be win-win, where agreements are created by taking care of the interests of both the sides. Negotiation requires interpersonal skills, communication skills as well as problem solving skills.

Types of negotiation

There are broadly two types of negotiation namely distributive negotiation and integrative negotiation.

In distributive negotiation, the parties area only looking for their gain. It leads to a win-lose kind of outcome. In distributive negotiation, negotiation is carried out more as anone time transaction, not keeping in mind any kind of long term relationship.

While in integrative negotiation, the negotiators look for long term relationships and they try to ensure value for both sides. It leads to a win-win outcome.

Approach for Negotiation

Negotiation can always be sensitive and should be carries out in a planned manner keeping in mind the end goals to be achieved. We should take care to ensure that negotiation does not get into an argumentative situation.

The negotiations process is made up of five stages:

1. Preparation and planning
2. Definition of ground rules
3. Clarification and justification
4. Bargaining and problem solving and
5. Closure and implementation

In order to achieve the desired outcomes from negotiation, it will be extremely important to do the initial homework. We must identify what we are looking at achieving from the negotiation. What are our best alternatives to a negotiated agreement. It is also important for us to understand about the expectations of the other party.

It is important to lay down the procedures for carrying out the negotiation, such as who will be part of negotiation, where the negotiation will happen and some basic ground rules to be followed.

Then the actual information and offers must be exchanged between the parties. Arguments and confrontations must be avoided in the process. At this stage the required bargaining should be done keeping good faith. Negotiation should always be done as a win-win outcome for both sides.

Once agreement is reached, the same should be implemented.

NEGOTIATION SKILLS

1. Communication

To achieve your ideal outcome at the bargaining table, it's essential to clearly communicate what you're hoping to walk away with and where your boundaries lie.

Effective negotiators develop communication skills that allow them to engage in civil discussion and work toward an agreeable solution.

Deal-making requires give and take; it's critical to articulate your thoughts and actively listen to others' ideas and needs. Not doing so can cause you to overlook key components of negotiations and leave them dissatisfied.

2. Emotional Intelligence

For better or worse, emotions play a role in negotiation, and you can use them to your advantage.

For example, positive emotions can increase feelings of trust at the bargaining table. Similarly, you can channel anxiety or nervousness into excitement.

You need a high degree of emotional intelligence to read other parties' emotions. This can enable you to pick up on what they're implying rather than explicitly stating and advantageously manage and use your emotions.

3. Planning

Planning ahead with a clear idea of what you hope to achieve and where your boundaries lie is essential to any negotiation. Without adequate preparation, you can overlook important terms of your deal or alternative solutions.

4. Value Creation

Value creation is one of the key skills you should add to your negotiation toolkit.

To illustrate its importance, consider this analogy: When participating in a negotiation, you and the other parties typically try to obtain the biggest "slice of the pie" possible. Vying to maximize your slice inherently means someone will get a smaller piece.

To avoid this, shift your goals from growing your slice to expanding the whole pie. The benefits of doing so are twofold: First, you can realize greater value; second, you can establish a sense of rapport and trust that benefits future discussions.

5. Strategy

In addition to thorough preparation and the ability to create value, you need a clear understanding of effective negotiation tactics. By knowing what works and what doesn't, you can tailor your strategy for every negotiation.

To develop a strong negotiation strategy, take the following steps:

- Define your role
- Understand your value
- Consider your counterpart's vantage point
- Check in with yourself
- Following this process can enable you to formulate a clear plan for the bargaining table. By understanding the roles of those involved, the value they offer, and their advantages, you can work toward a common goal. Checking in with yourself throughout the negotiation can also ensure you stay on the path to success.

- 6. Reflection

- Finally, to round out your negotiation skills and develop your proficiency, reflect on past negotiations and identify areas for improvement.

- After each negotiation—successful or not—think about what went well and what could have gone better. Doing so can allow you to evaluate the tactics that worked in your favour and those that fell short.

What is nonverbal communication?

Nonverbal communication sends cues to others using actions rather than words. People can express happiness, engagement, concern, gratitude and confidence by responding nonverbally.

This can include communication using hand gestures, eye contact, body language, appearance, facial expressions and tone of voice.

Nonverbal communication can be one of the strongest forms of communication between coworkers. It can take place in many workplace situations including meetings, interviews or casual conversations.

Situational examples of nonverbal communication in the workplace

1. Proper eye contact

Coworkers will often feel valued and appreciated if they know they're being heard. You can help them feel this way by making eye contact while they're speaking. Keeping your eyes on the person rather than on your computer, paperwork or cell phone lets them know you're listening to their input. Maintaining eye contact while you're replying to them also keeps the conversation engaging, and turning your camera on for video chats can build a respectful relationship between coworkers.

Example: *A coworker approaches you with an idea to increase collaboration in your department. Show that you are actively listening by maintaining eye contact and nodding in agreement.*

2. Positive tone of voice

Though the act of speaking is a part of verbal communication, how you speak can be considered nonverbal communication. Whether you are communicating in person or participating in a video conference call, always be aware of your tone of voice so it reflects your intended message. Maintaining a positive tone while talking with a coworker or supervisor can affect the energy of your whole conversation.

Example: *An employee is giving a presentation proposing a new client engagement plan. They use an energetic and positive tone to spark enthusiasm for the project. This increases the level of interest from senior management as they notice the employee express excitement and passion for the project.*

3. Personal appearance

The way you present yourself can create an impact greater than words might say. Your workplace appearance such as looking neat and prepared—even if you are in the comfort of your own home office—or keeping a tidy workstation can convey your self-confidence and make a positive impression on coworkers.

Example: *You hope to speak with a supervisor to ask for a raise or promotion, so dress in business attire to showcase your dedication to both the position and professionalism in the workplace.*

4. Good posture

The way you stand or sit at work can often display your attitude or attentiveness toward certain situations. Sitting or standing up straight can show you're engaged in the conversation while also portraying a confident appearance during an interview.

Example: *You are tasked with presenting a new idea to your supervisor and want to communicate effectively. You can sit or stand with your shoulders back to convey your confidence and why you believe your idea will benefit the company.*

5. Appropriate touch

Communicating through touch has evolved from the pre-COVID workplace. Even without social-distancing protocols, people have always varied in their comfort levels with touch. Developing your cultural intelligence can be a useful, rapport-building skill in the workplace.

Example: *In the United States, shaking a person's hand firmly shows respect or that you're pleased to meet them. In other cultures, it might be misconstrued as a sign of aggression. If you sense that it's appropriate, a slight touch on the arm or pat on the shoulder can also be a way to show your support or encouragement without vocally expressing it.*

6. Facial expressions

As people communicate with you, they often anticipate a nonverbal response by watching your facial expressions. Keep in mind that even during a virtual interview, your face can communicate what you're feeling or thinking without using any words. Smiling, nodding and using your eyebrows can indicate a positive reaction when having a conversation.

Example: *A coworker is telling you about their recent vacation, so you can smile and nod along while you listen to show you're enjoying their story.*

7. Personal space

During one-on-one conversations, you may move closer to the person you're speaking with. This shows that you're interested in having a conversation and want to hear them clearly. Try to make sure you're allowing enough space to maintain a comfortable environment for both of you.

Example: *Before you sit down for a meeting, you can select a seat closer to a coworker to hear them better.*

8. Hand gestures

The way you gesture or position your hands during conversations can convey how you're feeling. If you move your hands to build expression throughout stories, people can become

more engaged in what you're saying. Hand gestures can also express friendliness or appreciation.

Example: *A coworker is giving a presentation but they are uncertain about how others are receiving the information. A casual, yet discreet "thumbs up" can show them that it's going well.*

9. Body language

Your overall body language can showcase your feelings during a meeting or while carrying on a conversation. Keeping your arms relaxed at your sides expresses openness and a willingness to listen, but crossing your arms might indicate that you're closed off. You can also express politeness and undistracted attention by leaning forward in your seat.

Example: *As you watch a coworker give a presentation, you sit upright with your arms on the table. This shows you're engaged in their presentation. If you slouch in your seat, they may think you're disinterested.*

Why is nonverbal communication important?

By accurately interpreting the nonverbal cues of your coworkers, you can gain a shared understanding of their feelings, emotions and attitudes toward certain situations. Your ability to communicate with shared meaning can encourage collaboration with team members, which may boost productivity, enhance engagement and strengthen your cultural competence.

Being aware of your communication strategies can also help you convey your feelings on various subject matters or situations. It can also help you exude confidence when talking with supervisors or express empathy when listening to a coworker.